OOP Interface

PHP 5.2 introduced a set of classes (and interfaces) for interacting with dates and times that are pretty much the standard way of doing these things in PHP. If you're not sure what a class or interface is, go read Chapter 6, "Object Fundamentals," which covers everything you'll need to make sense of this next section. Let's start by listing all of the components in the API, then looking at them in detail:

Table 9-1. *`DateTime` classes*

`DateTime`	The main class for representing dates and times
`DateTimeImmutable`	Very similar to `DateTime` but does not allow any changes to its timestamp
`DateTimeInterface`	The interface to the classes above, defines many useful constants too
`DateTimeZone`	Class representing time zones
`DateInterval`	Class for representing differences between two times
`DatePeriod`	Implements `IteratorAggregate`; this class allows iteration over sets of dates/times, covering a set period

`DateTimeInterface`

This interface is implemented by `DateTime` and `DateTimeImmutable`, which are the two main classes you'll be using whenever your programming involves dates/times – or perhaps you might be using a library such as `Carbon` – `https://carbon.nesbot.com/` – which will be a wrapper around these core classes. `DateTimeInterface` offers around a dozen or so constants for formatting time: `DateTime` and `DateTimeImmutable` store a Unix timestamp integer value internally and offer a `format()` method that allows the timestamp to be expressed as a string in a multitude of ways; these constants are a way of maintaining consistency and offer compliance with various standard formats. We'll take a look at those formatting constants when we take the two implementing classes for a spin. The following public methods are also defined on `DateTimeInterface` and examined in detail in the implementing classes: